

IN CONTEXT

Wartime service

Aged 42 when World War I broke out, Vaughan Williams would have been exempt from call-up to the front line, but he insisted on joining, and was posted to northern France as an ambulance driver in the Royal Army Medical Corps. After further service in Greece, he was promoted to lieutenant and joined the Royal Artillery, again in France—probably the underlying cause of increasing deafness in his old age. In the months after the fighting stopped, he eagerly organized and conducted choral societies assembled from the troops before they were sent home.



RALPH VAUGHAN WILLIAMS AS AN
AMBULANCE DRIVER IN WORLD WAR

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Poetic inspirations

The second masterwork, *A Sea Symphony*, was first heard at the